TALENT HUNTER

MANISHA MALHOTRA KNOWS THE DIAMOND in a coal mine, and she knows what it needs to keep shining. The sports administrator has been part of India's sporting history not once but twice, working closely with ace shooter Abhinav Bindra and javelin star Neeraj Chopra in their quest for Olympic gold. At JSW, her roster currently includes Asian Games medallist athletes Avinash Sable, Murali Sreeshankar, Parul Chaudhary, cricketers Jemimah Rodrigues and Shafali Verma as well as several boxers and wrestlers.

Manisha is also on the lookout for the next big thing in Indian sports, as she welcomes the country's budding talent to the main centre of the Inspire Institute of Sport (IIS) in Vijayanagar, Karnataka, and its satellite centres in four states, where they can get the best of training and facilities. Instead of recruiting solely based on the opinion of coaches, she says, the IIS is also banking on sports science. "They (athletes) go through a battery of tests both in the lab and on the field for a month," she explains, "and are then compared to a database of already enrolled athletes and also against the world standards."

Of particular interest to Manisha is the cause of increasing women's participation in sports. "I like to support women also from a performance standpoint," she adds, "[as Indian] women have a greater chance of being world-beaters than men in several sports." Currently, the IIS Vijayanagar, which opened in 2018, has an equal number of male and female athletes. But with a new women's hostel being built, that figure is also set to change. She further credits IIS CEO Rushdee Warley with putting in processes to support women athletes—from intervening and convincing their families to sensitising coaches to training methods to be adopted during menstrual cycles.

There's a reason why Manisha has gained the trust of the athletes she works with. A former tennis player, who has competed in both the Olympics and Asian Games, she is familiar with the disciplined and demanding lifestyle and also the impediments faced, especially by young girls.

To scout for talent in athletics, judo, boxing, wrestling and swimming, Malhotra and her team's hunting grounds are district competitions and local club games. But identifying is just a part of what's a long journey with highs and lows. "What I learned from Abhinav and Neeraj and what we are trying to instil in each of our athletes is to get more holistically into the process and not just [think about] a goal," she says. "If you follow the process, results are just milestones." Meanwhile, Malhotra has set her sights on adding to India's Olympic kitty with JSW Sports recently signing what many believe is a bright star: 15-year-old Anahat Singh, senior national squash champion. ■

-Suhani Singh

Manisha Malhotra, *47*
Head of Sports Excellence & Scouting, JSW Sports



Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH

ACCOMPLISHMENT
Spearheads a programme that's nurturing talent and delivering medals

FIRM BELIEVER

"[Indian] women have a greater chance of being world-beaters than men in several sports"

↘ **BUCKET LIST Would love to see the NCAA Championship in women's volleyball that averages 50,000 spectators a match**